Cyberbullying

Building Resilience and Character
while creating safe spaces for our children

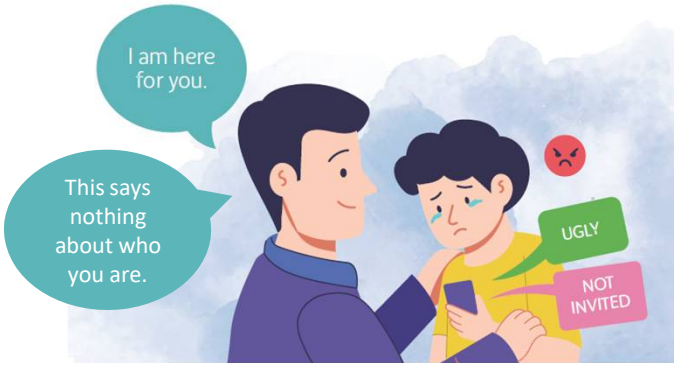
Did you know?

A 2025 Digital Parenting Survey (MDDI) found that **more than 50%** of parents are concerned about cyberbullying.

MOE supports parents with resources related to children's mental well-being, cyber wellness, and strengthening parent-child relationships.

Through **CCE lessons,** students understand that bullying and cyberbullying is wrong, and acquire skills to:

- cultivate empathy and be kind
- manage differences and resolve disagreements respectfully
- be assertive, manage negative influences and seek help
- stand up against bullying and support peers affected as upstanders and peer supporters,

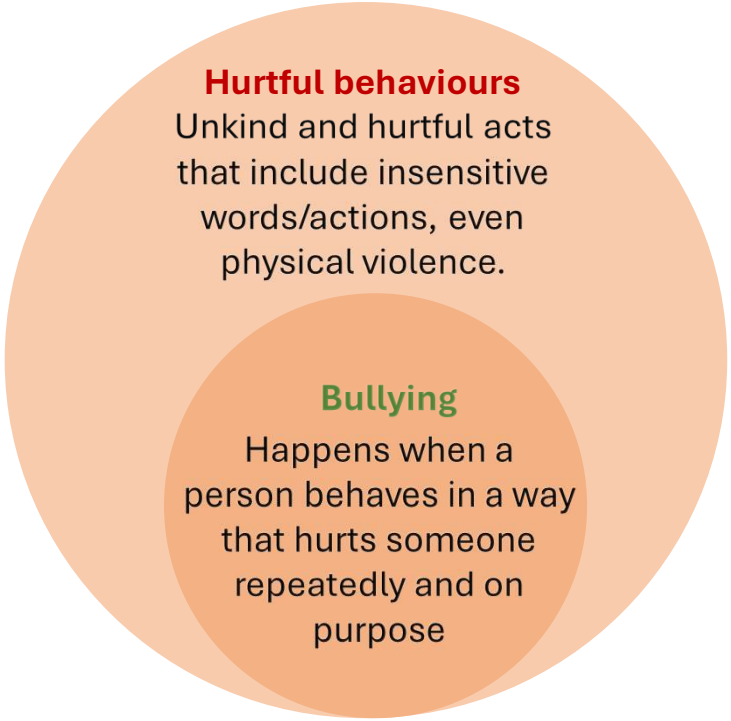


Source: Channel News Asia (12 Sep 2025)

What are hurtful behaviours and bullying?

In Singapore, local studies show that verbal/social bullying forms the bulk of the types of bullying experienced in schools and they often start as 'harmless teasing' or leaving someone out but escalate into bullying.

Hence, **we need to take a serious view of all forms of hurtful behaviours and bullying,** starting from once-off insensitive remarks before they become normalised or escalated.



Forms of hurtful behaviours/ bullying

Physical

Hitting someone or damaging someone's belongings, tends to occur alongside other forms of hurtful behaviours

It can extend from offline to online platforms, amplifying its visibility

Cyber

Hurtful behaviours/ bullying that occurs when online technology (e.g. mobile phones, computers or social media) is used as a means to hurt or upset someone on purpose and repeatedly (through sharing and/or resurfacing a post)

Some common forms of cyber bullying include flaming, harassment, cyber stalking, denigration, impersonation, exclusion, trickery and doxxing.

Social

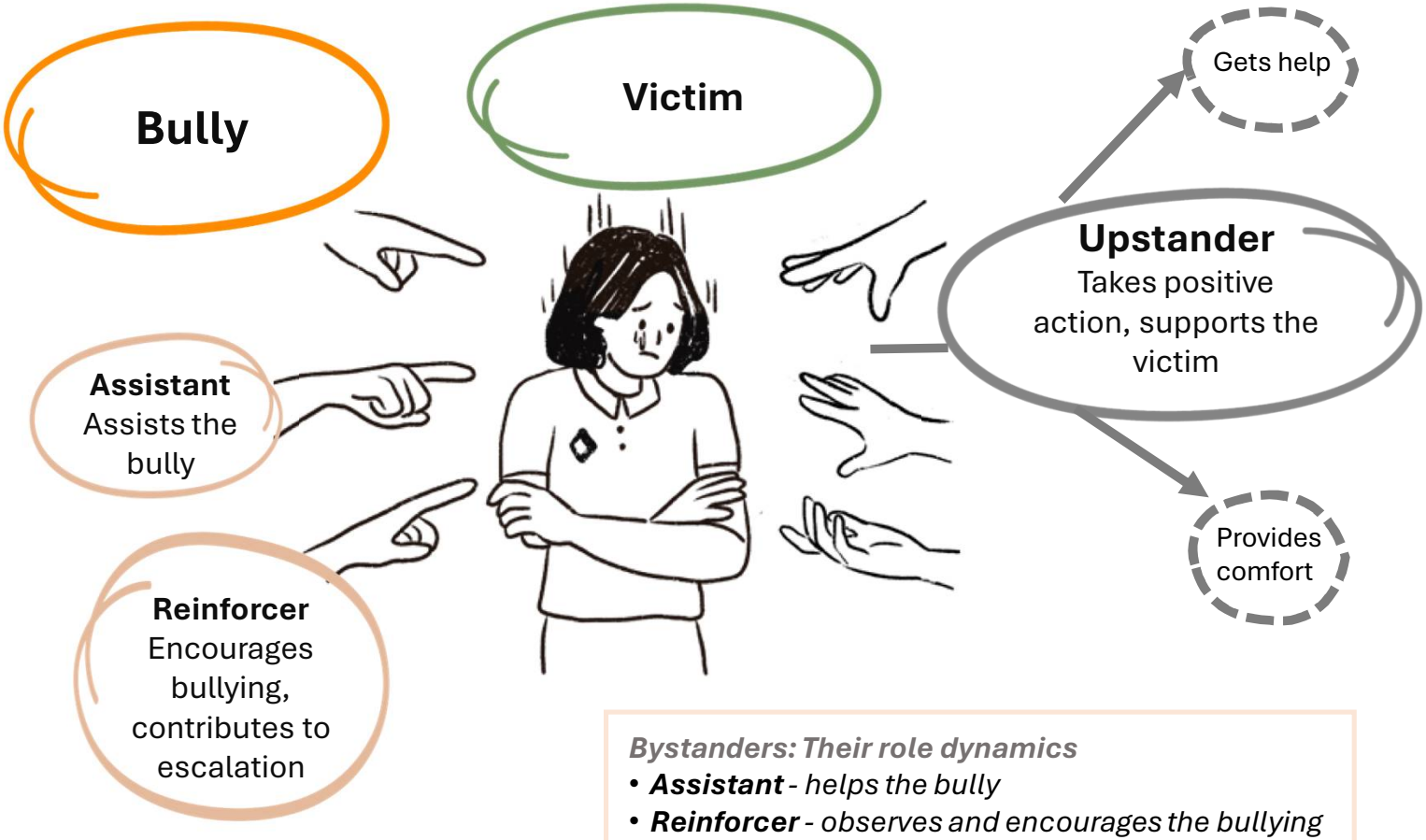
Leaving someone out of a group or things on purpose

Multiple forms of bullying could be experienced by the same student at the same time or sequentially.

Verbal

Name-calling, spreading rumours or making threats

Do you know the different roles* in bullying?



Bystanders: Their role dynamics

- ***Assistant*** *- helps the bully*
- ***Reinforcer*** *- observes and encourages the bullying*
- ***Upstander*** *- stands up against the hurtful behaviour, comforts the victim or gets help*
- ***Outsider*** *- avoids acting or taking sides*

*The terms used here are meant to provide a simplistic description and are not meant to label students.

How can I guide my child to be kind and respectful online?

Ask your child if what they are about to post or share online is… **T**ruthful, **H**elpful, **I**nspiring, **N**ecessary, and **K**ind (**T.H.I.N.K.**)?

T — **IS IT TRUE?**
Is this a fact or just an opinion or feeling?

H — **IS IT HELPFUL?**
Does it help you, them, or the situation?

I — **IS IT INSPIRING?**
Would it encourage, motivate, and make someone feel better?

N — **IS IT NECESSARY?**
Does it really have to be said, or you just want to or feel like saying it?

K — **IS IT KIND?**
Are you saying this with the intention to hurt someone's feelings?

If the answer to any of the above questions is "No", they should not post or share the content online, even if it is intended for their private social media account or private group chat.

By guiding your child to make it a habit to T.H.I.N.K. before posting or sharing anything online, your child learns to be kind and avoids hurting others with their online behaviour.

What are some signs of bullying?

Bully/Perpetrator

- Tends to be impulsive and aggressive
- Tends to have poor relationships or lack empathy with others
- May blame victims for their behaviour by saying things like, ‘if he/she were XX, I would not have XX’
- May appear anxious while using digital devices
- Tends to hide or turn off the monitor/devices when someone approaches

Victim/Targeted

- Becomes less sociable than usual around family and friends
- May struggle with studies or lose interest in school
- Becomes upset or anxious, especially when receiving messages or using devices
- Spends less time on the activities they used to enjoy
- May experience poor health as struggling with the bully saps the energy and ability to focus

Bystander

- May fear being targeted by the bully or straining relationships
- Tends to feel anxious and powerless about being unable to stop bullying
- May feel unsafe in class/school
- May experience guilt of not defending the victim

How can I help if my child is a victim?

#13 Resources on tips and strategies to support your child when they are cyberbullied are available at the end of the presentation.

Have a conversation using **C.H.E.E.R** as a guide to understand what they are experiencing.

Remain calm to assess the situation and provide emotional support to your child.

You can use C.H.E.E.R. to help guide your conversation.

Calm them down
Speak in a gentle tone.
→ You seem upset. Let's sit down and talk about it.

Hear them out
Lend them a listening ear.
→ It can be difficult to talk about being bullied. I want to understand how it's been for you so we can figure out what we can do together.

Empathise with their feelings
Acknowledge their feelings.
→ I see that you have been hurt by their actions. How about using I-Messages* to let them know that you are upset by what they posted? Sharing how you feel may help resolve any misunderstandings.

Encourage them to seek help
If it seems that the problem is beyond what your child can manage on their own, recommend reaching out for additional support.
→ It seems like this has been going on for a while and is bothering you a lot. Let's get some help to resolve the matter.

Reassure them
Let them know that you will always be there to support them and listen to their problems.
→ I'm always here for you. If this happens again or whenever you feel bothered by it, I'm here to listen.

** I-messages are used to communicate one's feelings and needs to others clearly and respectfully. For example, "I felt upset when you posted that photo of me making a funny face that made me look silly. I would need you to remove that photo, please."*

How can I help if my child is a victim?

#14 **Resources** on how to report incidents through online platforms are available at the end of the presentation.

How can I help if my child is the bully?

If you suspect that your child is cyberbullying others, remain calm. You can:

- Ask questions to understand what happened.
- Let them know that bullying is unacceptable. Encourage them to apologise sincerely and make amends to repair relationships.
- Monitor their online activities e.g. their social media posts
- Reach out for extra support from school.

Parents, your child's **behaviour change takes time** and requires consistent effort. You can build their character by **setting clear expectations** about treating others respectfully and **role-modelling** positive behaviours in your interactions.

#15 **Resources** on tips and strategies to support your child when they might be a cyberbully are available at the end of the presentation.

How can I help to guide my child to be an upstander?

If your child is involved in a cyberbullying incident as a bystander, **help them feel safe and supported**.

Remind your child **not to like, share, record or repost** the online message or media.

Guide your child to take on **upstanding behaviours** by:

- asking your child whether they want you to listen, to help with more ideas about what to do / how to support the victim or to help them to report the incident.
- letting your child know that it is okay if they don't feel safe or confident to stand up to bullying.

If you come to know that the hurtful behaviour continues, please approach the school and continue to support your child.